

90 Shortening infinitives

Phrases with infinitives can sometimes be reduced or shortened to prevent repetition. This helps language to sound more natural.

See also:
Infinitives and participles 51

90.1 REDUCED INFINITIVES

Instead of repeating the whole infinitive clause, "to" can be used on its own if the meaning remains clear.

Let's see that new DJ tonight.



I don't really want **to** [see the new DJ].

If the previous sentence or clause contains the verb "be," then the full infinitive "to be" must be used, rather than just "to."

She **was** really critical of the new album.



It's difficult not **to be** [critical of it].
The singing is awful!

FURTHER EXAMPLES



He asked me if I wanted to cook tonight, but I'd prefer not **to**.



All my friends are going to the basketball game, but I don't want **to**.



I was going to bring an umbrella, but I decided not **to**.



There **are** more flowers in the garden than there used **to be**.



This packaging **isn't** recyclable, but it ought **to be**.